



Rise. Register. Grow.

In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)

Journey 5: “Never Run Out of Stock Again”

This is **Journey 05** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.

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Journey 5: "Never Run Out of Stock Again"

"Running out of a popular item halfway through the day sends that customer straight to a competitor. Ordering too much carries the same risk in reverse."

Most small South African food businesses still order stock based on guesswork. Below is a simple system that needs no software or technical expertise, just a bit of daily discipline.

First In, First Out

"Yesterday's chicken is still in the back of the fridge. Which batch are you actually cooking with today?"

Know your "first in, first out" rule (FIFO). Always use or sell your oldest stock first, and put new deliveries behind existing stock, not in front of it. This is especially important for perishable food like meat, dairy, and vegetables (Xtraspace, 2024).

 **QUICK TIP** Make FIFO physical: literally move new stock to the back of the shelf or fridge every time a delivery arrives.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Check your fridge or storage now, is your oldest stock at the front, ready to be used first?

Complete this and earn:  "FIFO Focused" badge

Set Your Par Levels

"How many kilograms of mealie meal do you need left before you start to worry?"

Set a simple "par level" for your top and best-selling items. Decide, from experience, on the minimum amount of each item you should have before you need to reorder, for example: "if I have less than 5kg of mealie meal left, I need to restock before my next trading day."

 **QUICK TIP** Your par level doesn't need to be scientific. Your own experience of what "running low" feels like is a perfectly good starting point.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Name any of your top 3 best-selling items and set a simple par level ("I reorder when I have less than ____") for each.

Complete this and earn:  "Par Level Pro" badge

Track What Runs Out

"You sold out of vetkoek by 11am again. Is that a coincidence, or a pattern?"

Check stock at the same time every day, ideally at the end of your trading, so it pairs naturally with your daily notebook routine. Write down what you sold out of, and when. If you notice you're consistently selling out of an item by midday, that's your sign to increase your order for that item.

 **QUICK TIP** A pattern only becomes visible once it's written down. Two or three sellouts noted in the same notebook page tell you far more than memory alone.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Tonight, write down what you sold out of, and roughly when it happened.

Complete this and earn:  "Pattern Spotter" badge

Order Smart, Not by Guesswork

"Your veggies spoil before you sell them, but you never run out of packaging. What does that tell you about how you're ordering?"

Match your ordering to your trading pattern. If certain items frequently get spoiled, order in smaller amounts more frequently for those (fresh vegetables, meat), while ordering slightly larger amounts less often for things that last longer (dry goods, packaging, disposables). Build reliable supplier relationships too, a supplier



who knows you will often prioritise you when stock is tight, or give you advance warning of price changes (Ready Accounting, 2026).

 **QUICK TIP** A five-minute conversation with your supplier about your usual order can save you an unplanned trip, or an unplanned shortage.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Pick one perishable item and one dry good, and write a smarter ordering plan for each.

Complete this and earn:  "Smart Stocker" badge

Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrcs.org.za.
- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — dffe.gov.za.
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — dtic.gov.za.
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — info regulator.org.za.
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — gov.za.
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — dtic.gov.za.

Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.

Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. Cloudfusion.co.za.
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? Brandingmag.



- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. candyfoxstudio.com.
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. iKhokha.

Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.

Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. nationaldebtadvisors.co.za.
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. startupmag.co.za; Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. lula.co.za.
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. regenesys.net/reginsights.
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. graduates24.com.
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. okhantu.co.za.
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. readyaccounting.co.za.
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. xtraspace.co.za.

Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. Harvard Business Review, 92(1/2), 27.

